

“You have sent me the **most valuable information** received from Richmond during the war.”

PRESIDENT LINCOLN SPEAKING OF ELIZABETH VAN LEW

Interpreting data

Successful intelligence hinged on the ability to analyze and interpret information. As well as running espionage and counterespionage rings, Pinkerton, who remained a civilian, was hired by General George B. McClellan as intelligence chief for the Army of the Potomac. But his naive interpretations of data meant he often gave McClellan gross overestimates of Confederate army strength, which the general's overcautious disposition made him only too ready to believe.

An organized military surveillance system was not set up until January 1863, when General Joseph Hooker took command of the Army of the Potomac. He ordered Colonel George H. Sharpe to set up a unit, which became the Bureau of Military Information. Sharpe's organization marked a great step forward in professionalism and it would further flourish under Ulysses S. Grant's command in 1864.

The Confederacy never achieved this level of organization. Much of its “secret war” was conducted abroad, agents playing an important role in Europe by procuring arms and ships in defiance of neutrality laws. In 1864 the Confederacy set up a unit in Canada to undertake operations across the border into the North. Supporters carried out acts of sabotage but fell far short of their aim of detaching the northwestern states from the Union.